Diaries

H 1538

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A. Background

Diaries are registers or records of personal experiences, observations, thoughts, or feelings, kept daily or at frequent intervals. They are usually written as an aid to memory or reflection and are customarily intended for private rather than public use. The procedures below describe the specific treatment of works consisting of true personal diaries. This instruction sheet is not intended to cover memoirs, reminiscences, or personal narratives of events that are not in diary entry form and contemporaneous with the events described. It is also not intended to be applied to official logs of activities.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Diaries***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Groups Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***German speakers*** or ***Arabic, Students of***.

For guidelines on bio-bibliography, see H 1328. For guidelines on biography, see H 1530. For guidelines on interviews, see H 1678. For guidelines on personal narratives of wars or disasters, see H 1928. For guidelines on genealogy and family histories, see H 1631.

B. Recent revisions

2026-07: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. Definitions

Diaries: registers or records of personal experiences, observations, thoughts, or feelings, kept daily or at frequent intervals, customarily intended for private use

D. Array of headings

Assign the following array of headings to individual diaries or collections of diaries.

LC practice: Assign an appropriate combination of subject heading(s) for an individual diary or collection of diaries. See the more detailed guidance below regarding each category of subject heading. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Diaries***.

Model:

```
600 X0 $a [name of diarist(s)] $v Diaries.
650 #0 $a [class of persons, or ethnic group] $v Diaries.
650 #0 $a [special topics discussed in the diary or diaries].
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LC practice:

```
600 X0 $a [name of diarist(s)].
650 #0 $a [class of persons, or ethnic group].
650 #0 $a [special topics discussed in the diary or diaries].
655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft
```

E. Individual diarists

Assign as subject headings the name or names of the individual writers of the diaries, up to a maximum of three. Subdivide the name(s) by the free-floating form subdivision ***--Diaries***. If there are more than three diarists, do not designate any individual writer.

LC practice: Assign as subject headings the name or names of the individual writers of the diaries, up to a maximum of three. Also assign the LCGFT term appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Diaries***.

F. [Class of persons, or ethnic group]--Diaries

Assign headings of the type ***[class of persons or ethnic group]--Diaries*** if the writer(s) of the diary or diaries can be identified with a particular subject area or discipline or a particular ethnic group.

LC practice: Assign a subject heading for classes of persons or ethnic group if that is a topic in the diary. Also assign the LCGFT term appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Diaries***.

Examples:

650 #0 $a African Americans $v Diaries.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a African Americans.
655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft

650 #0 $a Dramatists, German $y 20th century $v Diaries.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Dramatists, German $y 20th century.
655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft

610 20 $a Episcopal Church $x Clergy $v Diaries.

LC practice:

610 20 $a Episcopal Church $x Clergy.
655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft

650 #0 $a Painters $z Great Britain $v Diaries.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Painters $z Great Britain.
655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft

650 #0 $a Women plantation owners $z Southern States $v Diaries.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Women plantation owners $z Southern States.
655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft

For works of only a single diarist, do not assign both a class of persons heading and an ethnic group heading to the same work. Prefer the class of persons heading.

G. Special topics

If the diary contains information about topics not covered by headings of the type ***[class of persons]--Diaries*** or ***[ethnic group]--Diaries***, assign additional headings for the topics,

including headings such as ***[place]--Biography*** (cf. H 1330, sec. 1.c.) or ***[Individual war or event]--Personal narratives*** (cf. H 1928), if appropriate.

Since the diary or diaries of any individual person may or may not be regarded as historical source material, depending upon the viewpoint of the reader, do not add the subdivision ***--Sources*** or ***--History--Sources*** to the additional headings assigned for special topics.

LC practice: If the diary contains information about topics not covered the types of headings described in Sections E-F, assign additional headings for the topics, including headings such as ***[place]*** (cf. H 1330, sec. 1.c.) or ***[Individual war or event]*** (cf. H 1928), if appropriate. Also assign the LCGFT term appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Diaries*** or ***Personal narratives***.

H. Diaries as a literary genre

Headings of the type ***American diaries***; ***English diaries***; ***Japanese diaries***; etc., are literary genre headings. Assign such headings only to collections of diaries by more than one writer that are classed as literary works. If the collection is not limited to an individual body of literature, assign the heading ***Diaries***.

LC practice: Assign an appropriate combination of subject heading(s) for a diary or diaries. If a subject heading for literary genre brings out the nationality and/or ethnicity of the writers, continue to supply it. Optionally, assign the creator characteristics with LCDGT, e.g. ***Germans*** and/or ***Novelists***. If it is describing just the genre/form of the content, do not provide a subject heading to express that. Instead, assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Diaries***.

I. Extended examples

```
Title: Tagebücher, 1918 1921.
   600 10 $a Mann, Thomas, $d 1875 1955 $v Diaries.
   650 #0 $a Novelists, German $y 20th century $v Diaries.
LC practice:
   386 ## $a Germans $2 lcdgt
   600 10 $a Mann, Thomas, $d 1875 1955.
   650 #0 $a Novelists, German $y 20th century.
   655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft


Title: New England year : a journal of Vermont farm life.
   600 10 $a Follett, Muriel $v Diaries.
```

650 #0 $a Country life $z Vermont.

650 #0 $a Farm life $z Vermont.

651 #0 $a Vermont $x Social life and customs.

LC practice:

600 10 $a Follett, Muriel.

650 #0 $a Country life $z Vermont.

650 #0 $a Farm life $z Vermont.

651 #0 $a Vermont $x Social life and customs.

655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft

Title: War diaries : November 1939 March 1940.

600 10 $a Sartre, Jean-Paul, $d 1905 1980 $v Diaries.

650 #0 $a Authors, French $y 20th century $v Diaries.

650 #0 $a World War, 1939 1945 $v Personal narratives, French.

650 #0 $a World War, 1939 1945 $z France.

LC practice:

600 10 $a Sartre, Jean-Paul, $d 1905 1980.

650 #0 $a Authors, French $y 20th century.

650 #0 $a World War, 1939 1945 $z France.

655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft

Title: American diaries of World War II.

650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945 $v Personal narratives, American.

651 #0 $a United States $x Armed Forces $v Diaries.

LC practice:

386 ## $a Americans $2 lcdgt

650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945.

651 #0 $a United States $x Armed Forces.

655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft

Title: God's galloping girl : the Peace River diaries of Monica Storrs, 1929-1931.

600 10 $a Storrs, Monica, $d 1888-1967 $v Diaries.

650 #0 $a Frontier and pioneer life $z Peace River Region (B.C. and Alta.)

650 #0 $a Anglicans $z Peace River Region (B.C. and Alta.) $v Diaries.

650 #0 $a Pioneers $z Peace River Region (B.C. and Alta.) $v Diaries.

651 #0 $a Peace River Region (B.C. and Alta.) $v Biography.

LC practice:

600 10 $a Storrs, Monica, $d 1888-1967.

650 #0 $a Frontier and pioneer life $z Peace River Region (B.C. and Alta.)

650 #0 $a Anglicans $z Peace River Region (B.C. and Alta.).

650 #0 $a Pioneers $z Peace River Region (B.C. and Alta.).

651 #0 $a Peace River Region (B.C. and Alta.).

655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft

Title: "I -" : an anthology of diarists.

650 #0 $a English diaries.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a English diaries.

655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft

Revision history

2026-07: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.